

CASE STUDY — VASA FITNESS MOBILE APP

Better Than Starbucks

How a 10-person team built what Starbucks couldn't with 70

Replacing a broken white-label gym app with a custom native experience — shipped to both app stores in under six months, through a pandemic, with a junior dev team and a timeline that shouldn't have worked.

Ted Potter — UX Project Lead → UX Lead

Client: VASA Fitness • Agency: Neudesic

Timeline: 2019–2021 · 13 months active • Platform: iOS & Android Native

My Role & Impact

Led UX across iOS and Android for a 10-person cross-functional team

Defined product direction to replace an underperforming white-label app

Established decision-making frameworks (card sorts, priority matrices) to reduce misalignment and scope creep

Bridged client leadership and delivery team — presenting to C-suite stakeholders and running side-by-side dev reviews

Mentored junior engineers through hands-on design reviews, raising implementation quality across both platforms

Delivered a new mobile experience to both app stores within a 6-month timeline

300,000 installs and \$150,000 in direct app revenue within three months of launch

Ten people, two platforms, six months

The consulting world doesn't ease you in. You show up on day one already behind — the client has been thinking about this project for months, the timeline was set before you were staffed, and your team is a mix of people who've never worked together. That was the VASA Fitness engagement in the summer of 2019.

Our team was about ten people, all Neudesic. A couple of senior leads, and then a group of junior developers — several of whom were building their first native iOS or Android app. The energy was chaotic in the way that early-stage consulting projects always are: everyone figuring out their role, the client figuring out what they actually want, standups that run long because nobody's sure which decisions have been made yet. But it was also exciting. The kind of project where the whiteboard is always full, where someone grabs you on the way to lunch to sketch an idea on a napkin, and where the work moves fast enough that what you design this week might be in a build next week.

The assignment was clear, even if the path wasn't: VASA Fitness, a national gym chain, needed a real mobile app. What they had wasn't working. And they needed it live in both app stores by Thanksgiving — less than six months away.

A white-labeled app nobody liked

VASA's existing app was a Netpulse white-label — a generic template product shared across dozens of gym brands. It looked like a VASA app on the surface, but underneath it was a hollow shell. All of VASA's real member data — accounts, class schedules, payments, KidCare reservations — lived in a completely separate system called PAC. The Netpulse app and PAC didn't talk to each other in any meaningful way.

The result, for members, was maddening. You'd open the app, log in, and then get launched into a browser window inside the app where you'd have to log in again — to a completely different system — just to see your class

schedule. Two logins, two interfaces, no continuity. It felt like the app was actively working against you.

And for a member like the one we kept coming back to throughout the project — a single mom in her early thirties who drops her two kids at KidCare before her morning class — the app was useless for the thing she needed most. KidCare scheduling wasn't available through any digital system at all. She had to call the front desk or walk in and do it manually. Every single time. We wanted her to open the app on Sunday night, schedule her KidCare and classes for the week in two minutes, and get on with her evening. That was the bar we designed toward.

VASA knew this was broken. They'd tried to work within the Netpulse framework and hit walls everywhere. They wanted something they owned entirely — an app that connected to their actual data, that they could evolve on their own terms, and that could become a real digital channel to their members. That's what they hired us to build.

What eight thousand members told us

Before we designed a single screen, we surveyed over 8,000 VASA members. The scale of that response was unusual for a project like this — it gave us a dataset that was hard to argue with when it came time to make priority calls.

Three findings shaped the entire product direction.

First, the average member dropped off after about eighteen months. Retention wasn't just a nice-to-have metric — it was the core business problem VASA needed the app to address. Second, roughly 70% of VASA's members were on iOS. That informed our platform priority and where we invested the most design energy. Third — and this was the one that reframed everything — the single loudest frustration across thousands of responses was simple: members couldn't access or manage their own accounts through the app. Not "we want fancier features" or "the design feels dated." Just: let me see my own account. Let me book a class without logging in twice.

The old app was a marketing brochure pretending to be a product. The data told us our job was to give it an identity.

Designing inside someone else's system

Here's where consulting projects get interesting: we didn't control the data. Every feature we designed had to work within the API boundaries of PAC, the third-party platform that held all of VASA's member information — accounts, payments, class schedules, everything. PAC wasn't built to power a modern mobile app. It was built to manage gym operations from the back office.

This constraint shaped every design decision. It wasn't enough to ask "what's the best experience?" — we had to constantly ask "what can PAC actually give us?" That meant designing screens, discovering a data field wasn't exposed through the API, and getting creative about what we could surface and how.

KidCare scheduling was a perfect example. Members had been calling the front desk to book childcare because no system supported it digitally. We had to work with PAC to figure out what data was available, what scheduling logic could be built on top of it, and how to present it in the app as something that felt native — not bolted on. Making that work was one of the quiet wins of the project, because from the member's perspective, it just worked. She had no idea what was happening underneath. She just opened the app, booked her two KidCare slots for the week, and moved on.

Making it look like VASA

VASA's brand had been built for print and marketing — billboards, gym signage, promotional flyers. Translating that into a native mobile experience meant extending the brand into a medium it had never lived in. I worked directly with VASA's Chief Brand & Marketing Officer, Mindi Bridges, through rounds of moodboards, style tiles, and early concept designs to lock the visual direction before building a single production screen. That early investment paid dividends: when design questions came up later, we had a shared vocabulary vetted at the top, which meant I could move fast and

make visual decisions with confidence rather than looping back for approval on every screen. From there, I designed over 390 screens across three major phases and multiple updates.

Shipping in the real world

The Phase 1 launch target was November 2019 — timed to a Thanksgiving marketing push. That gave us less than six months from kickoff to both app stores. For a custom native app on two platforms, with a junior dev team and third-party API dependencies, that's a tight window.

What shipped in Phase 1 was the core product: barcode check-in, class and KidCare scheduling, a membership purchase flow, gym locations, a homescreen, and — critically — real account access. Members could finally see their own membership information inside the app that bore their gym's name. The thing the old app couldn't do, ours did from day one.

As the deadline closed in, it became clear we couldn't deliver the same level of quality on both platforms. The team had to make a tradeoff: delay the launch to bring Android up to parity, or ship on time and accept a gap between platforms.

We shipped on time, knowing exactly where the gaps were.

The iOS experience was strong — the version the C-suite ended up raving about. Android was functional, but it carried compromises we weren't proud of: interaction patterns that didn't feel quite right, areas where polish wasn't there yet.

My role in that moment wasn't deciding the tradeoff, but making sure what we shipped still made sense as a product. That meant focusing design effort where it would have the most impact, tightening the core flows, and working closely with developers to ensure that even where we cut corners, the experience still held together.

The decision wasn't comfortable. But it was grounded in the reality of the product: with roughly 70% of VASA's members on iOS, we were delivering a

high-quality experience to the majority while still replacing something broken for everyone else.

We treated Android as a gap to close, not a permanent state. In the updates that followed, we brought it up to the level it should have been at launch.

We hit the Thanksgiving launch window and established a foundation we could iterate on immediately.

Getting there also required a way of working I hadn't fully anticipated. About two-thirds of the development team were junior engineers learning native iOS or Android for the first time. A Figma handoff wasn't going to cut it — these developers were simultaneously learning a new platform, a new codebase, and how to interpret design specs.

So I started doing side-by-side reviews. I'd sit with a developer, pull up the build on a device next to the design in Figma, and we'd walk through it together — pixel by pixel when it mattered, but more importantly, talking through intent. Why this spacing exists. Why this element is interactive and that one isn't. What the user is trying to accomplish on this screen and how the layout supports that. It wasn't just QA — it was teaching them to see the design the way a designer sees it.

At peak velocity, that 1:5 designer-to-developer ratio meant I spent 50-70% of each working day in these reviews. It was exhausting, but it was the single most important thing I did for product quality. The developers didn't just build better screens as the project progressed — they started catching issues on their own, asking better questions before building, and developing an instinct for when something looked off. That's the part that doesn't show up in a shipped feature list, but it's the reason the features shipped at the quality they did.

The Slack message

Shortly after launch, a message from Mehul Chaudhari — VASA's VP of Strategy and Analysis — made its way to our team through Slack. It got screenshotted and passed around to every person on the project:

“Just got a call from our CEO/CMO/CFO who are using the app today to book classes and got feedback from the club. They said it was awesome and were super happy with it. They made an app at Starbucks with 70 developers and a bunch of other folks and couldn’t release it in the same timeframe or for the same cost.”

— Mehul Chaudhari, VP of Strategy and Analysis, VASA Fitness

That’s the kind of thing you hold onto in consulting. You don’t always get to hear how the work landed — you hand off the project and move on to the next one. When a client’s entire C-suite is using your app to book their own gym classes and comparing it favorably to what Starbucks built with seven times the headcount, it tells you the work connected.

The iOS app launched with a 4.3 rating on the App Store — a rating it still holds today across nearly 7,000 reviews — and hit 300,000 installs within three months. VASA recorded \$150,000 in sales flowing directly through the app in the months following launch.

Then the world stopped

On March 19, 2020, VASA closed every gym in response to COVID-19. Member accounts were frozen. Most staff were furloughed. Revenue dropped to zero overnight. All vendor work — including ours — halted immediately.

For about three months, the project didn’t exist. We’d shipped a successful Phase 1, the numbers were strong, the client was happy, and then none of that mattered because nobody was going to the gym anymore. It was the kind of interruption you can’t plan for and can’t design around. You just wait.

When VASA reopened and started bringing vendors back, Neudesic was one of the first calls they made. That decision — choosing to reinvest in the app before most other vendor relationships — was a direct result of the trust built during Phase 1. We picked up where we left off, but with sharper focus and a team that already knew how to work together. That trust eventually

led to two additional projects — a guest kiosk tool and a self-service support site — both designed and shipped during the pandemic recovery, when every budget line was being scrutinized.

Deciding what to build next

Phase 2 presented a different kind of problem than Phase 1. The first time around, the priorities were obvious: ship the basics, replace the broken thing, give members account access. But after launch, the feature backlog exploded. VASA had a long list of ideas — referrals, gamification, rewards, social features, check-in history, profile customization — and everyone had opinions about what should come next.

Without a framework for deciding, we'd have spent weeks in stakeholder debates or, worse, tried to build everything at once. So I facilitated a card sort exercise with Mehul Chaudhari to force prioritization. We laid out every candidate feature, mapped them against member impact and technical feasibility, and sorted them into a sequenced roadmap. The exercise did what it needed to do: it turned a sprawling wishlist into a focused plan that the entire team — VASA's leadership, our developers, and the product group — could align around.

That kind of facilitation is invisible in a shipped product, but it's often the thing that determines whether a Phase 2 ships on time or collapses under scope creep. My job wasn't just to design the features — it was to help the client decide which features deserved to exist at all.

Growing the product

With the roadmap locked, Phase 2 deepened member engagement. We added member referrals, check-in history, profile photo uploads, the ability to change your home gym, and a gamification system with badges — features designed to make the app feel personal, not just functional.

One structural call I wish we'd made earlier was splitting iOS and Android into dedicated teams. In Phase 1, developers were context-switching between platforms, losing momentum on both. By Phase 2, I advocated for

the split, and once it happened, velocity improved immediately. It's the kind of process decision that doesn't feel like design work, but it directly affected what we could ship and how fast.

Phase 3, in September 2021, introduced a full rewards program integrated with a third-party vending platform. Members could track points, see their rewards overview, and redeem directly through the app. It created a new retention loop — a reason to open the app even on days you didn't go to the gym.

Becoming the lead

Six months into the engagement, the principal designer moved on and I stepped into the UX Lead role. The shift changed my day-to-day in ways I didn't fully anticipate.

As UX Lead, I was no longer just designing screens and doing side-by-side build reviews. I was presenting directly to VASA's stakeholders, defining the product roadmap, writing user stories, managing the backlog, and keeping priorities aligned across a team that now spanned multiple workstreams and two platform-specific dev groups. I became the primary bridge between VASA's leadership and our delivery team — translating business goals into design direction in stakeholder meetings, then translating design intent into implementation specifics in developer reviews. Two different audiences, two different languages, same product vision.

Ownership also meant caring about the product after it shipped. I wrote the app store update notes for each release and personally responded to user reviews — the kind of work that doesn't show up in anyone's job description but signals to the client (and to the members) that someone on the team is paying attention to the full experience, not just the Figma file.

Mindi later described the dynamic in a way that meant a lot to me:

"Not only was Neudesic involved on the technical side, but they also became a strategic advisor on new features that we were looking to implement. Neudesic understood how we operate our business on a day-to-day basis and helped make

recommendations. This took a lot of pressure off of our team, because we trusted that Neudesic had our best interests in mind.”

— Mindi Bridges, Chief Brand & Marketing Officer, VASA Fitness

That trust didn't come from a single moment. It came from showing up consistently — facilitating the card sorts, presenting design rationale in language stakeholders cared about, catching implementation issues before they became client-facing bugs, and being honest about what we could and couldn't deliver in a given sprint. When a client starts treating you as a strategic partner rather than a vendor executing a spec, that's the signal that you're operating at the right altitude.

What this work proved

A project like this doesn't succeed because everything goes right. It succeeds because the team learns how to make decisions quickly, align around what matters, and move forward even when the path isn't clean.

For VASA, that meant focusing on the few things that would actually change the member experience — real account access, class and KidCare scheduling, and a product that felt like it belonged to them, not a template shared with dozens of other gyms.

For me, it reinforced where design has the most impact. Not just in the screens, but in how decisions get made — helping a team converge, giving developers enough context to build with confidence, and making tradeoffs explicit so the product can actually ship.

The Starbucks comparison is the part people remember. The 4.3-star rating, the 300,000 installs, the revenue — those are easy signals of success.

What mattered more was that the product worked. Members could do the things they needed to do without friction. The team could build on it. And the client trusted us enough to keep going.

If I could talk to the version of myself standing in that first chaotic standup — surrounded by whiteboards, junior developers, and a timeline that felt impossible — I'd tell him it's going to work.

But only if you learn how to make the right calls before you have perfect information.

Sources

Neudesic + VASA Fitness Case Study — neudesic.com/case-study/vasa-fitness

Includes independently published client quotes from Mehul Chaudhari (VP of Strategy & Analysis) and Mindi Bridges (Chief Brand & Marketing Officer), business impact metrics, and a downloadable PDF.

VASA Fitness Mobile on the App Store — apps.apple.com/us/app/vasa-fitness-mobile/id1486665906

4.3 stars across 6,900+ ratings. The app is still live and actively maintained.

VASA Fitness on Google Play — play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.vasafitness.members

4.2 stars across 3,100+ ratings, 500K+ downloads. Also still live and actively maintained.